

that a message will actually be delivered to the recipient. Delay or complete loss of a message is not uncommon, particularly when sending between networks. Users may choose to request delivery reports that can provide positive confirmation that the message has reached the intended recipient, but notifications for failed deliveries are unreliable at best.

Larger content (known as long SMS or concatenated SMS) are sent over multiple messages. Many would experience this when they receive a rather long message in smaller bits. While the standard theoretically permits up to 255 segments, three- to four-segment messages are the practical maximum, and long messages are billed as equivalent to multiple SMS messages.

Short messages can also be used to send binary content such as ring tones and logos as well. These are dependent on the operator extension of the GSM specification, and there are multiple competing standards—although Nokia’s Smart Messaging is by far the most common.

SMS is widely used to deliver premium content such as news alerts, financial information, logos and ring tones. Such messages are also known as premium-rated short messages (PSMS), and subscribers are charged extra for receiving this premium content. The amount is typically split with the mobile network operator and the content provider.

Premium short messages are also increasingly being used for “real-world” services. For example, some vending machines now allow payment by sending a premium-rated short message, so that the cost of the item bought is added to the user’s phone bill.

Short message services are developing rapidly throughout the world. In 2004, people around the world sent more than 500 billion messages. The concept is very popular in Asian countries, as we do not have to pay to receive SMSes—unlike our American